DEDICATED FREIGHT CORRIDOR

The Indian Railways has mostly had a mixed traffic of freight and passenger trains plying on its tracks. Now, work is on to create a distinct, dedicated network to carry freight across the country. Not only will this enhance capacity and efficiency, and reduce congestion, it will also increase the railways' freight share by a significant margin.

Bringing this together is the Dedicated Freight Corridor of India Limited (DFCCIL), a Public Sector Undertaking, formed in 2006 with the aim to plan, build, operate, and maintain freight-carrying corridors across the country.

The decision to build dedicated freight corridors came about under the Eleventh Five Year Plan (2007–12), which focused on "inclusive growth". The plan referred to the massive strain placed on the Delhi–Mumbai and Delhi–Kolkata routes because of the "rapid rise in international trade and domestic cargo". The first step to easing this strain lay in building dedicated freight corridors along "high density routes", starting with two in the west and east sectors, respectively. This involved constructing 7,201 km of new rail tracks. "This will help to decongest the two routes for freight movement and also increase the economic potential of the hinterland areas, which will benefit from the reduced cost of transport. It will also provide spin-off benefits in terms of the location of industrial clusters along the new corridors, thereby attracting potential investment in a number of states," the plan stated.

The DFCCIL is now in the process of constructing five freight corridors that span the length and breadth of India, of which two are under construction and surveys are underway for two others. These will be laid east to west with Kolkata–Mumbai (2,328 km), north to south with Delhi–Chennai (2,327 km), along the east coast with Kharagpur–Vijayawada (1,115 km), and along the south-west Chennai–Goa corridor, which is still under consideration. Apart from easing the strain on the existing infrastructure, these corridors are expected to integrate the domestic market and provide an industrial boost to the economy.